Three Mistakes Families Make When Everything About a Husband's Care Feels Urgent

What each one looks like, why it happens, and what to do in its place.

In a week like this one, most families slip into the same three habits. None of them is a failing. Each is what happens when a great deal arrives at once, and each has a plain alternative.

1 Trying to do everything at once

WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE By mid-morning you've called the rehab back, started on the pharmacy's questions and opened your daughter's list. By evening none of the three is finished, and the list is longer than it was.

WHY IT HAPPENS When several things arrive in the same week, they all look equally due. On one list, a choice, a chore and a thing to find out look alike, so each one gets the same attention.

> **WHAT TO DO INSTEAD** Sort the list into decisions, tasks and open questions. Then find the decision with the nearest date that somebody actually gave you, and start with that one. AARP's planning guide describes a similar first pass: see where there is an immediate need, then prioritize the remaining tasks and develop a timeline. [1]

2 Taking a step before what it depends on is settled

WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE The rehab gets an answer on Tuesday, and on Wednesday his doctor tells you something that changes it. Or rides and help get lined up around a day nobody had confirmed.

WHY IT HAPPENS Somebody is waiting, and answering feels like progress. The Family Caregiver Alliance gives families a related caution about meetings: until the issues have been explored, it's important not to try to solve the problems. Recording them in a list, it says, is useful. [2]

> **WHAT TO DO INSTEAD** Under the next decision, write what it depends on and who can settle each item: the family, his doctor or nurse, the pharmacist, the discharge planner. Ask those questions first. Medicare's discharge checklist tells caregivers to write their questions down and discuss them with the staff. [3]

3 Leaving one relative to coordinate every task

WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE Your name is beside nearly everything: the calls, the forms, the pharmacy, the driving. People have offered to help, and nobody has been handed anything in particular.

WHY IT HAPPENS It happens a little at a time. The Family Caregiver Alliance, writing about brothers and sisters caring for a parent, notes that families often don't think through who becomes the primary caregiver, and that the others may assume that person has everything covered. AARP's guide says caring for a family member can be too big a job for one person. [4] [1]

> **WHAT TO DO INSTEAD** Write the tasks down and look at the names. Then ask: MedlinePlus suggests making a list of ways others can help and letting helpers choose what they'd like to do. Put a name on a task only when that person has agreed, and tell the hospital staff what you can and can't take on. [5] [6]

The one habit behind all three

Before you act on an item, write it down with three things beside it: what kind of item it is, what it's waiting on, and whose it is.

What this guide doesn't do

It doesn't tell you which decision comes first for your family, what to answer anyone, or who should take which task. It names three habits, the same three the Family Care Roadmap sees at this step.

Ready for the next step?

You know the three habits to set down and what to do in place of each. The care interview gives the new habits something to work on: it walks you through your husband's situation area by area and turns your answers into a Family Care Profile you can bring to any care conversation.

Create Your Free Family Care Profile ›

WHERE THIS COMES FROM

The advice with a number beside it comes from the sources below. The three mistakes are the Family Care Roadmap's own.

1. AARP, Prepare to Care: A Planning Guide for Families
2. Family Caregiver Alliance, Holding a Family Meeting
3. Centers for Medicare & Medicaid Services, Your Discharge Planning Checklist (CMS Product No. 11376)
4. Family Caregiver Alliance, Caregiving with Your Siblings
5. MedlinePlus (National Library of Medicine, NIH), Caregiver Health
6. Family Caregiver Alliance, Hospital Discharge Planning: A Guide for Families and Caregivers

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